

Diagnosis Pocket Companion

Eight Principles · The 28 Pulses
EAM310 · Weeks 2–3

Jonathan Centeno · VUIM D.AcHM

How this book works

Every entry has two parts.

Top — what Schrier taught. Straight from the lecture slides and transcripts. This is what gets examined.

BOTTOM — PLAIN LANGUAGE

Drawn from outside references to make the thing easier to actually *feel* or picture. Use it to build intuition; use the top half to answer questions.

sources named per entry

Own these five first: Floating · Deep · Slow · Rapid · Full. Schrier's Week 3 instruction, verbatim. Everything else is for the written exam.

The pulse never stands alone. Think Rapid? Ask about thirst, heat, sweating; look for a red tongue with yellow coat. Think Slow? Ask if they run cold. The pulse confirms — it does not decide.

Eight Principles

八纲 Bā Gāng — 表里 · 寒热 · 虚实 · 阴阳

Four axes, not eight boxes. Every patient sits somewhere on each of:
Exterior/Interior (where) · Cold/Heat (nature) · Deficiency/Excess (strength) · Yin/Yang (the summary of the other three).

Axis	Fastest test
Exterior / Interior	Simultaneous chills AND fever + Floating pulse = Exterior
Cold / Heat	Thirst, drink preference, urine colour, tongue coat
Deficiency / Excess	Pressure: relieved = Deficiency · aggravated = Excess
Yin / Yang	Read off the other three

Schrier's formulas: Yang def = Qi deficiency signs + cold. Yin def = Blood deficiency signs + heat.

Exterior

表 Biǎo

PRESENTS AS

Aversion to cold and fever occurring TOGETHER, aching body, stiff neck, Floating pulse. Sudden onset, short duration, early stage.

ARISES FROM

Invasion of the superficial portion of the body by an exogenous pathogen.

Key discriminator

The pairing is everything. The moment the aversion to cold disappears while fever persists, the pathogen has moved Interior.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Think of the body as a walled city under attack from outside. Fighting at the wall makes you feel both the cold outside and the heat of the battle at once — that simultaneity is the whole diagnosis.

Kaptchuk · Maciocia

Interior

里 Lǐ

PRESENTS AS

No simultaneous aversion to cold, Deep pulse. Located in the five Zang and six Fu.

ARISES FROM

Either an exterior pathogen transmitted inward, or functional disturbance of the Zang-Fu themselves.

Key discriminator

Interior also tells you the DIRECTION of travel. Exterior → Interior means the disease is advancing.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Exterior/Interior isn't strictly anatomical depth — it's a statement about where the fight is happening and which way it's moving.

Maciocia

Exterior Cold

表寒

PRESENTS AS

Slight fever, pronounced aversion to cold, severe body aches, severe stiff neck, NO sweating, no thirst. Floating-Tight pulse, thin white coating.

ARISES FROM

Wind-Cold invasion.

Key discriminator

No sweating plus severe aches is the Full Exterior picture.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Cold contracts. The pores shut (no sweat), the muscles seize (severe aches), the vessel tightens (Tight pulse). One mechanism, three signs.

Kaptchuk

Exterior Heat

表热

PRESENTS AS

Fever, mild aversion to cold, sore throat, thirst. Floating-Rapid pulse.

ARISES FROM

Wind-Heat invasion.

Key discriminator

Sore throat is the reliable early differentiator from Exterior Cold.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat rises and disperses — so it shows first at the top and outside: throat, head, skin.

Maciocia

Full Exterior

表实

PRESENTS AS

Fever, NO sweating, severe body aches, aversion to cold. Floating-Tight pulse, thin white coating.

ARISES FROM

Strong pathogen meeting strong Zheng Qi.

Key discriminator

No sweating = Full.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The gate is shut and both armies are strong. Nothing is leaking out.

Maciocia

Empty Exterior

表虚

PRESENTS AS

Slight or NO fever, sweating present, aversion to WIND, slight body aches.
Floating-Slow pulse, thin white coating.

ARISES FROM

Weak Wei Qi failing to secure the exterior.

Key discriminator

Sweating plus aversion to wind rather than cold.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The gate won't close. Sweat escapes, and moving air feels intolerable because there's no defence at the surface.

Maciocia

Full Cold

实寒

PRESENTS AS

Feeling cold, cold limbs, no thirst, pale face, abdominal pain
AGGRAVATED by pressure, desire for warm drinks, loose stools, clear abundant urine. Deep-Full-Tight pulse, Pale tongue with THICK white coating.

ARISES FROM

Excess of Yin. Cold foods, iced drinks, or external Cold penetrating inward.

Key discriminator

Face bright-white · pain sharp and worse on pressure · better after a bowel movement.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Something is physically there and obstructing — that's why pressure hurts. Excess always resents pressure.

Maciocia FCM Table 30.2

Empty Cold

虚寒

PRESENTS AS

Feeling cold, cold limbs, DULL pale face, no thirst, listlessness, sweating, loose stools, clear abundant urine. Deep-Slow or Weak pulse, Pale tongue with THIN white coating.

ARISES FROM

Deficiency of Yang. Overwork, inadequate warm food, excessive sexual activity, internal Cold injuring Yang.

Key discriminator

Face dull-white · pain dull and BETTER on pressure · worse after a bowel movement.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Nothing is there to obstruct — the problem is absence. Pressure adds the support that's missing, so it helps.

Maciocia FCM Table 30.2

Full Heat

实热

PRESENTS AS

Thirst, feeling of heat, mental restlessness, RED FACE (whole face), dry stools, scanty dark urine. Rapid-Full pulse, Red tongue with YELLOW coating.

ARISES FROM

Excess Yang. Emotional problems; diet (red meat, spices, alcohol); an exterior pathogen penetrating inward and transforming to Heat.

Key discriminator

High fever · very restless and agitated · profuse sweating · loud voice · thirst for cold drinks.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A fire with fuel. Loud, red, dry, and outward. Everything about it is additive.

Maciocia

Empty Heat

虚热

PRESENTS AS

Heat in the afternoon or evening, dry mouth wanting small sips, dry throat AT NIGHT, night sweating, five-palm heat (chest, palms, soles), dry stools, scanty dark urine. Floating-Empty-Rapid pulse, Red tongue with NO coating.

ARISES FROM

Deficiency of Yin — Yin consumed over time, leaving Yang relatively in excess. Overwork, irregular eating, excessive sexual activity, heavy blood loss.

Key discriminator

MALAR FLUSH only, not whole face · low-grade afternoon fever · vague anxiety · thin red tongue, NO coating.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Not a bigger fire — a smaller pond. The heat is relative, which is why it's timed (afternoon, night) rather than constant.

Maciocia

Full / Excess

实 Shí

PRESENTS AS

Pain AGGRAVATED by pressure, forceful pulse, loud voice, robust build, agitation, thick tongue coating.

ARISES FROM

A pathogenic factor is present and the body's Qi is still strong enough to fight it.

Key discriminator

Pressure response is the single fastest differentiator in the entire Eight Principles.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Excess = something present that shouldn't be. Deficiency = something absent that should be. Press: if it hurts more, something is there.

Kaptchuk · Maciocia

Empty / Deficiency

虚 Xū

PRESENTS AS

Pain RELIEVED by pressure and warmth, weak pulse, quiet voice, fatigue, thin or no coating.

ARISES FROM

The body's own Qi, Blood, Yin, or Yang is insufficient.

Key discriminator

Deficiency likes pressure. Excess resents it.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same test, opposite answer. It works because you're asking whether adding is welcome or unwelcome.

Kaptchuk

Yin Pattern

阴 Yīn

PRESENTS AS

Groups Interior + Cold + Deficiency. Quiet, slow, pale, cold, withdrawn, weak pulse.

ARISES FROM

The master category — everything Yin-natured collapses into it.

Key discriminator

If you can place a patient on the other three pairs, Yin/Yang is already decided.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Yin/Yang isn't a fourth independent question — it's the summary of the first three.

Kaptchuk

Yang Pattern

阳 Yáng

PRESENTS AS

Groups Exterior + Heat + Excess. Loud, fast, red, hot, agitated, forceful pulse.

ARISES FROM

The master category for everything Yang-natured.

Key discriminator

Yang = faster, louder, more active. Yin = slower, quieter, less.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Use it as a sanity check: if you've called something Interior-Cold-Deficient, it should read as Yin overall. If it doesn't, re-examine.

Kaptchuk

False Heat, True Cold

真寒假热

PRESENTS AS

Red cheeks but the colour is POWDER-LIKE and the rest of the face is white; irritability but also listlessness; wants to lie curled up; thirst but NO desire to drink, or wants WARM fluids; body feels hot but the patient wants to be COVERED; sore throat without redness or swelling; pale urine; quiet breathing, low voice. Pale wet tongue. Pulse Rapid, Floating, Big but EMPTY.

ARISES FROM

Interior Cold forcing the remaining Yang outward and upward.

Key discriminator

This is NOT Empty-Heat. In Empty-Heat there really is Heat. Here the Heat appearance is false — there is no Heat at all.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A dying fire flaring at the edges. The flare looks like heat but the hearth is cold. Ask about drinks and covers — the patient's own preference gives it away.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

False Cold, True Heat

真热假寒

PRESENTS AS

Dark face with BRIGHT eyes and 'spirit'; red-dry lips; irritability with a strong body; thirst WITH desire for cold fluids; scanty dark urine; constipation; burning in the anus; noisy breathing, loud voice. Red-dry tongue body. Pulse Deep and FULL — cold limbs but the CHEST IS HOT.

ARISES FROM

Full Heat so intense it drives Yang inward and away from the extremities.

Key discriminator

Cold limbs but a hot chest. Feel the chest, not just the hands.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The furnace is roaring but the doors are shut, so the outside feels cool. Everything central — voice, eyes, thirst, urine — reports the real state.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Cold Exterior, Heat Interior

表寒里热

PRESENTS AS

Fever with aversion to cold, no sweating, headache and stiff neck, body aches (exterior Cold) PLUS irritability and thirst (interior Heat).

ARISES FROM

Pre-existing interior Heat, then invaded by exterior Wind-Cold.

Key discriminator

Both pictures are genuinely present — this is not a false appearance.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Two real problems stacked, not one problem in disguise. Treat both.

Maciocia

Heat Exterior, Cold Interior

表热里寒

PRESENTS AS

Fever with aversion to cold, sore throat, thirst, headache, Floating-Rapid pulse PLUS loose stools, chilliness, profuse pale urine.

ARISES FROM

Pre-existing Cold condition, then attacked by exterior Wind-Heat.

Key discriminator

Upper/outer Heat signs with lower/inner Cold signs.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Mirror image of the above. Again both are real.

Maciocia

Heat Above, Cold Below

上热下寒

PRESENTS AS

Above: thirst, irritability, sour regurgitation, bitter taste, mouth ulcers.

Below: loose stools, borborygmi, profuse pale urine.

ARISES FROM

Heat rises, Cold descends — they separate rather than mixing.

Key discriminator

Mouth ulcers with loose stools is the classic pairing.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat naturally goes up and Cold naturally goes down, so when both exist they stratify. The body layers rather than averages.

Maciocia

Combined Heat and Cold

寒热错杂

PRESENTS AS

Manifestations of both simply coexisting.

ARISES FROM

Extremely common in practice — e.g. Kidney-Yang deficiency with Damp-Heat in the Bladder, or Spleen-Yang deficiency with Liver-Fire.

Key discriminator

Don't force a single label. Real patients are frequently both.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The Eight Principles are axes, not boxes. A patient occupies a position on each one independently.

Kaptchuk

Pulse Diagnosis

脈診 — The 28 Qualities

Before you palpate

Do	Why
Ask permission, every time	Non-negotiable — and it settles them
Arm horizontal, not above heart level	Bends impede flow
Index=Cùn, middle=Guān, ring=Chǐ	Middle finger always on Guān
All three fingers down first	Overall impression before positions
Your right hand → their left wrist	Reverse if seated same-side
Let them settle	Stairs, cold, a heavy meal all move the pulse
Note time and season	Both shift the pulse independent of pathology
Count against YOUR breath	Breathe naturally — don't engineer it

Fingers are not held still. Still only when counting rate. Otherwise press/lift for depth, roll for length, push medial-lateral for shape.

Three depths

Depth	How to find it	Reflects
Superficial	Light contact, just the skin	Qi
Middle	Press to bone, obliterate, release <i>slowly</i>	Blood
Deep	Press to bone level	Yin organs

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The middle is the one everyone skips because it has no landmark. Find your two anchors first — surface and bone — then travel slowly between them. The middle announces itself as a change, not as a place.

Maciocia · Shen Hammer

Six positions — Nan Jing

	Left	Right
寸 Cùn Upper Burner	Hand Taiyang / SI · Hand Shaoyin / HT	Hand Yangming / LI · Hand Taiyin / LU
關 Guān Middle Burner	Foot Shaoyang / GB · Foot Jueyin / LR	Foot Yangming / ST · Foot Taiyin / SP
尺 Chǐ Lower Burner	Foot Taiyang / BL · Foot Shaoyin / KD	Hand Shaoyang / TB · Hand Jueyin / PC

Quick: L = HT · LR · KD | R = LU · SP · PC

Normal & seasonal

胃神根	Means
胃 Wèi	Flowing, gentle, harmonious movement
神 Shén	Strong, rhythmical — vitality present in the beat
根 Gēn	Depth felt at Chǐ — Kidney Qi intact under firm pressure

Rate: 4–5 beats per your breath, 60–90 bpm.

Season	Pulse	Dates
Spring	Wiry 弦	Feb 4 – May 4
Summer	Flooding 洪	May 5 – Aug 6
Autumn	Hair-like / Floating 毛	Aug 7 – Nov 6
Winter	Stone / Deep 石	Nov 7 – Feb 3

Seasonal ≠ normal automatically. Only when nothing else corroborates pathology. Flooding in *winter* is a warning — Schrier's case ended in a fatal cerebral hemorrhage.

Floating

浮 Fú

FEEL

Felt distinctly at the superficial depth; force decreases slightly deeper but never feels empty.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Wood floating on the surface of water; a subtle breeze across a bird's back; scallion leaves rolled lightly between the fingers.

INDICATES

Invasion of external Wind. Yin Deficiency (interior condition presenting superficially).

Not to be confused with

vs **Yin Def**: Exterior needs simultaneous chills AND fever.

COMBINATIONS

Floating-Weak — External-Empty — weak Wei Qi failing to react properly to external pathogenic invasion

Floating-Empty — Summer-Heat invasion (floats MORE) vs. Yin Deficiency (floats less) — degree is the differentiator

Floating-Slippery — invasion of Wind-Damp, or Wind complicated by Phlegm

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Put a ping-pong ball in water and press it. It rises to meet your finger, dips when you push, springs back the moment you ease off. Or a boogie board floating in a pool — something is definitely there at the top, but little substance underneath. It comes UP to meet you rather than sitting under your finger.

Then what

Now ask: chills and fever at the same time? Stiff neck? Stuffy nose? If yes — Exterior. If instead you get night sweats, hot palms and soles, a flushed patch on the cheeks, and a throat that's dry at night — that's Yin Deficiency wearing the same costume.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Deep / Submerged

沉 Chén

FEEL

Located deep next to the bone; barely felt with light or moderate pressure; only felt pressing to bone and tendons.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A stone thrown into a well, sinking to the bottom.

INDICATES

Pathogenic factor in the Interior (Deep-Full). Yang Deficiency (Deep-Weak).

Not to be confused with

vs **Hidden**: Hidden can't be found until bone-level pressure.

COMBINATIONS

Deep-Weak — Yang Deficiency

Deep-Wiry — Blood Stasis, or a Chong Mai issue

Deep-Wiry-Slow — Blood stasis due to Cold, or Cold stagnating in the Liver channel

Deep-Slow — interior Cold

Deep-Rapid — interior Heat

Deep-Soggy-Slow — Dampness in the Interior

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Nothing at all on light touch — beginners often conclude there's no pulse. Keep pressing toward the bone and it appears. Like feeling for a stone at the bottom of a pond.

Then what

Once you've found it, ask whether it's strong or weak down there. Deep + forceful = a pathogen sitting in the Interior. Deep + feeble = Yang Deficiency. Same depth, opposite treatment.

Maciocia

Slow

遲 *Chí*

FEEL

Fewer than three beats per breath, about 40–60bpm, regular rhythm.

INDICATES

Cold pattern. Empty-Cold (Slow+Weak). Full-Cold (Slow+Full).

Not to be confused with

vs **Huǎn**: Slow is under 3/breath. Huǎn is 4 — and healthy.

COMBINATIONS

Slow-Floating — exterior Wind-Cold with prevalence of Wind

Slow-Deep — interior Cold

Slow-Slippy — Cold-Phlegm or Damp-Cold

Slow-Choppy — Blood Deficiency and interior Cold

Slow-Weak — Empty-Cold with Yang Deficiency

Slow-Full — internal Cold, often chronic painful conditions

Slow-Wiry — stagnation of Cold in the Liver channel

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Not dramatic — just unhurried. You'll notice you're waiting between beats while breathing normally.

Then what

COUNT IT. Under 3 per breath is Slow. Four is Huǎn, which is healthy. This single count is the most common careless error in the whole unit.

Maciocia

Rapid

數 Shuò

FEEL

Over five beats per breath, 90–140bpm, regular rhythm.

INDICATES

Heat pattern. Full-Heat (Rapid+Full). Empty-Heat (Rapid+Floating-Empty).

COMBINATIONS

Rapid-Full — Full-Heat from Excess of Yang

Rapid-Empty — Empty-Heat from Deficiency of Yin

Rapid-Fine / Rapid-Floating — External Wind-Heat

Rapid-Deep — interior Heat

Rapid-Overflowing — Full-Heat

Rapid-Wiry — Liver-Fire

Rapid-Slippery — Phlegm-Heat

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It feels busy. You can't finish a comfortable breath before five or more beats have gone by.

Then what

Before calling it Heat, ask whether they rushed in, climbed stairs, or are anxious. Settle them two minutes and re-take. Exertion produces a rapid pulse that means nothing.

Maciocia

Empty / Deficient

虛 Xū

FEEL

Wide but without strength; forceless at all three positions under light or heavy pressure; a sense of emptiness.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A water balloon — big on the outside, nothing solid when you press in.

INDICATES

Qi Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Scattered**: Empty keeps its shape; Scattered loses it and can't be counted.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A water balloon. Wide across, but press in and nothing solid pushes back. The vessel is broad and the content isn't filling it.

Then what

Confirm with the person, not the wrist: tired? short of breath? quiet voice? Does pressure on a sore spot feel GOOD? Deficiency welcomes pressure.

Schrier · Maciocia

Full / Excessive

實 *Shí*

FEEL

Felt at all three positions and all three depths; long, wide, and forceful.

INDICATES

Full pattern. Full-Heat (Full+Rapid). Full-Cold (Full+Slow).

Not to be confused with

vs **Overflowing**: Full does not decay.

COMBINATIONS

Full-Rapid — Full-Heat

Full-Slow — Full-Cold

Full-Tight — Full-Cold

Full-Slippery — Phlegm

Full-Long — Heat

Full-Wiry — Full Liver pattern

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It meets you everywhere — light, medium, deep, all three positions, pushing back at every one.

Then what

Ask whether pressure makes anything worse. Excess resents pressure. Then decide Heat or Cold: thirst and dark urine, or cold limbs and clear urine.

Maciocia

Slippery

滑 Huá

FEEL

Feels quick though not rapid; slippery and smooth; rounded inside the vessel, as if oily.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A pearl rolling on a plate; a raindrop gliding off a leaf.

INDICATES

Phlegm. Dampness. Retention of food. Pregnancy.

Not to be confused with

vs **Moving**: Slippery glides throughout; Moving bounces at one point.

COMBINATIONS

Slippery-Floating — Wind-Phlegm

Slippery-Rapid — Damp-Heat or Phlegm-Heat

Slippery-Slow — Damp-Cold or Cold-Phlegm

Slippery-Big — Phlegm-Heat with predominance of Heat

Slippery-Short — Dampness or Phlegm with Qi Deficiency

Slippery-Weak — Dampness or Phlegm with Qi Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A wet grape or a ball bearing rolling under your fingertip. Smooth, rounded, faintly oily — it slides rather than bumps.

Then what

Ask about heaviness, muzzy-headedness, appetite, and recent meals. If relevant, ask "are you trying to conceive?" — never "are you pregnant?"

Maciocia · Deadman

Choppy

湖
波 Sè

FEEL

Seems slow and is not smooth; vessel is thin; rhythm irregular in force and fullness; feels rough, jagged.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Scraping bamboo with a small knife.

INDICATES

Blood Deficiency. Exhaustion of Body Fluids.

Not to be confused with

vs **Fine**: Choppy is rough and uneven; Fine is smooth, merely narrow.

COMBINATIONS

Choppy-Weak — depletion of both Qi and Blood

Choppy-Minute — extreme Blood Deficiency

Choppy-Soggy — Qi and Blood Deficiency with some Dampness

Choppy-Floating — invasion of external Wind

Choppy-Deep — longstanding Blood Deficiency

Choppy-Full — Blood Stasis (potentially)

Choppy-Knotted — Blood Stasis from Yang Deficiency and internal Cold

Choppy-Fine — Deficiency of Body Fluids

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Drag a fingernail across corduroy, or a small blade across bamboo. It catches and releases, uneven in force beat to beat. The exact opposite sensation to Slippery.

Then what

Look for Blood Deficiency signs: pale lips, dizziness on standing, poor memory, scanty periods. If instead you find fixed stabbing pain and purple lips, you're looking at Blood Stasis.

Maciocia

Long

長 Cháng

FEEL

Smooth and straight; felt extending distally and proximally beyond the usual positions.

INDICATES

Heat patterns.

COMBINATIONS

Long-Rapid — internal Heat

Long-Floating — external Wind-Heat

Long-Deep — internal Heat

Long-Wiry — Liver disharmony (usually excess)

Long-Slippery — Phlegm-Heat

Long-Overflowing — excess of Yang and Heat

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It runs past where you expect it to stop — extending beyond the three finger positions in one or both directions.

Then what

Long usually means something is expanding outward: Heat, or Liver-Yang rising. Check for irritability, headache, red face.

Maciocia

Short

短 Duǎn

FEEL

Cannot be felt in all three positions; absent at the distal and/or proximal position.

INDICATES

Severe Qi Deficiency. Stomach-Qi Deficiency.

COMBINATIONS

Short-Floating — Lung-Qi Deficiency

Short-Choppy — Heart-Qi Deficiency

Short-Rapid — severe Heart-Blood Deficiency with Empty-Heat

Short-Slow — Yang Deficiency with internal Cold

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

The reverse — it doesn't fill the span. One of your three fingers finds nothing while the others do.

Then what

Note WHICH finger comes up empty. Missing at the front (Cùn) points somewhere different from missing at the rear (Chǐ).

Maciocia

Overflowing / Flooding

洪 Hóng

FEEL

Wide and forceful, though it fades gently; vessel wide and thick.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Ocean waves that come strongly but leave calmly.

INDICATES

Full-Heat. Empty-Heat (Overflowing-Empty).

Not to be confused with

vs **Full**: Overflowing fades gently; Full is uniform at every depth.

COMBINATIONS

Overflowing-Floating — Wind-Heat with intense Heat — can progress quickly to the Qi level

Overflowing-Deep — internal Heat

Overflowing-Slippery — Phlegm-Heat with prevalence of Heat

Overflowing-Soft — Yin Deficiency with exhaustion of Body Fluids and Empty-Heat

Overflowing-Tight — Painful Obstruction (Bi) Syndrome

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A wave that arrives with real force and then recedes gently. Strong arrival, soft departure. That asymmetry is what separates it from Full.

Then what

Check the calendar. In summer this may be entirely normal. In WINTER it is a warning sign and you should not wave it away.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Fine / Thin

細 Xi

FEEL

Very thin, like a fine thread, but distinct and clear without interruption of rhythm under pressure.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Angel-hair pasta rather than a thick udon noodle.

INDICATES

Blood Deficiency. Dampness with severe Qi Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Minute**: Fine stays clear and continuous. Minute fades in and out.

COMBINATIONS

Fine-Rapid — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat

Fine-Wiry — Liver-Qi Stagnation

Fine-Tight — Empty-Cold with underlying Blood Deficiency

Fine-Choppy — severe Blood or Essence Deficiency

Fine-Weak — severe Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Angel-hair pasta rather than udon. Narrow, but perfectly clear and continuous — you can trace it without losing it.

Then what

Thin means not enough substance filling the vessel — think Blood. Add Rapid to it and you have Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat.

Schrier · Maciocia

Minute / Faint

微 Wēi

FEEL

Extremely thin and forceless; seems felt, then not felt; pressing deeply the vessel becomes vague.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Now you see it, now you don't.

INDICATES

Severe deficiency of Qi and Blood.

Not to be confused with

vs **Fine**: Minute is thin AND forceless.

COMBINATIONS

Minute-Rapid — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat

Minute-Slow — severe Qi & Blood Deficiency with internal Cold

Minute-Choppy — exhaustion of Blood

Minute-Soggy — Qi & Blood Deficiency with Dampness

Minute-Wiry — Liver-Yang rising with underlying Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

There, then not there. You catch it, lose it, catch it again. Thin AND weak — the combination is what makes it Minute rather than Fine.

Then what

This is a depletion finding, not a subtle one. Take it seriously and look at the whole person.

Maciocia

Tight

緊 Jǐn

FEEL

Rises and falls with strength, vibrating left and right; feels twisted like a thick rope.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Fingers on a highly stretched twisted cord, snapping back and forth.

INDICATES

Cold — Exterior (Tight-Floating), Interior Full-Cold (Tight-Full-Deep), Interior Empty-Cold (Tight-Weak-Deep). Pain.

Not to be confused with

vs **Wiry**: Tight snaps side to side; Wiry holds a straight line.

COMBINATIONS

Tight-Floating — Wind-Cold invasion, prevalence of Cold

Tight-Deep — internal Full-Cold

Tight-Choppy — Cold Bi Syndrome

Tight-Slippery — Cold-Phlegm

Tight-Firm — Blood Stasis from Cold

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A rope being twisted under your fingers — it doesn't just push up, it snaps side to side. A rubber band pulled taut and plucked.

Then what

Tight means Cold or pain. Ask where it hurts, and whether warmth helps. Cold contracts: shut pores, seized muscles, tight vessel — one mechanism, three signs.

Maciocia

Wiry

弦 Xián

FEEL

Taut, long, and forceful whether pressed or not; maintains a straight line beneath the fingers.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A spring stretched on a musical instrument; a guitar string about to snap.

INDICATES

Liver disharmony. Pain. Phlegm.

Not to be confused with

vs **Tight**: Wiry is a stable line. Also normal in Spring.

COMBINATIONS

Wiry-Rapid — Liver-Fire

Wiry-Slow — stagnation of Cold in the Liver channel

Wiry-Long — Liver-Qi Stagnation or Liver-Blood Stasis

Wiry-Tight — Blood Stasis

Wiry-Big — Liver-Fire or Liver-Yang rising

Wiry-Overflowing — Liver-Fire

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A guitar or bowstring. Straight, taut, and it HOLDS that line — no lateral wobble. Press harder and it stays a line.

Then what

Ask about stress, frustration, sighing, tension under the ribs. But check the season first — Wiry is normal in spring if nothing else corroborates.

Schrier · Maciocia

Slowed-Down / Moderate

緩 Huǎn

FEEL

Beats four times per breath — faster than the Slow pulse.

INDICATES

Generally a HEALTHY pulse — the one qualitatively normal entry on this list.

Not to be confused with

vs **Slow**: Huǎn is 4/breath and normal. Slow is under 3 and means Cold.

COMBINATIONS

Slowed-Down-Soggy — Dampness with Spleen-Qi Deficiency

Slowed-Down-Slippery — Cold-Dampness

Slowed-Down-Fine — Qi and Blood Deficiency

Slowed-Down-Floating — weakness of the Wei Qi

Slowed-Down-Deep — weakness of the Ying Qi

Slowed-Down-Choppy — Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Relaxed and even. Nothing draws attention to itself. If your reaction is "this seems fine," that reaction is probably correct.

Then what

This is the one healthy pulse among the 28. Count to confirm — 4 per breath. Then stop looking for pathology that isn't there.

Maciocia

Hollow

芤 Kōu

FEEL

Wide and soft when touched lightly, hollow when seeking; edges clearly felt under pressure but the center is obscure.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A scallion stalk — has an edge but is hollow inside.

INDICATES

Hemorrhage. Forthcoming hemorrhage (Hollow+Rapid). Yin Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Leather**: Hollow is soft at the surface; Leather is forceful there.

COMBINATIONS

Hollow-Rapid — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat, or impending hemorrhage

Hollow-Empty-Soggy — loss of Essence or depletion of Blood

Hollow-Knotted — Yang Deficiency or Blood Stasis

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Press the flat of a scallion, or a drinking straw. You feel the walls clearly on either side and emptiness in the middle. Present at the surface, present deep, absent between.

Then what

Ask directly about blood loss — heavy periods, recent injury, surgery, childbirth. Hollow plus Rapid can signal bleeding that hasn't happened yet.

Maciocia

Leather

革 Gé

FEEL

Large, thick, and wide; rapid and forceful when lightly touched, but hollow when pressed deeply.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

The surface of a drum — thick on top, hollow beneath.

INDICATES

Severe Kidney-Essence Deficiency. Severe Kidney-Yin Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Hollow**: both hollow beneath — Leather meets you with force first.

COMBINATIONS

Leather-Rapid — severe Deficiency of Yin with Empty-Heat

Leather-Slow — severe Blood Deficiency with Blood Stasis

Leather-Choppy — severe Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A drum head. Taut and forceful on top, nothing underneath. Where Hollow is soft at the surface, Leather meets you firmly first.

Then what

This points to deep Essence or Yin depletion — usually long-standing, often following major loss. Not a same-week finding.

Maciocia

Firm / Confined

牢 Láo

FEEL

Deep, taut, long, wide, and forceful; deeply located, cannot be felt with light or moderate pressure.

INDICATES

Blood Stasis. Interior Cold (Firm+Slow). Pain.

Not to be confused with

vs **Deep**: Firm adds taut, long, wide and forceful.

COMBINATIONS

Firm-Tight — internal Cold

Firm-Slow — internal Cold and Blood Stasis

Firm-Choppy — Blood Stasis

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Deep like a stone, but a stone with tension in it — long, wide, and forceful once you reach it.

Then what

Look for fixed masses, fixed pain, or long-standing Cold. Firm is Deep with attitude.

Maciocia

Soggy

濡 RÚ

FEEL

Superficial, thin, and forceless; grows weaker and weaker the more it is pressed.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A strand of cotton floating on water; a bubble that bursts under light pressure.

INDICATES

Dampness with Qi Deficiency. Yin Deficiency. Essence Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Weak**: Soggy floats; Weak sits deep.

COMBINATIONS

Soggy-Fine — severe Spleen-Qi Deficiency

Soggy-Choppy — exhaustion of Blood

Soggy-Floating — Deficiency of Wei Qi with Dampness

Soggy-Wiry — Dampness with Liver-Qi Stagnation

Soggy-Rapid — Damp-Heat

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Wet cotton wool floating on water, or a soap bubble. It's up at the surface, but the harder you press the more it dissolves.

Then what

Damp plus weakness. Ask about heaviness in the limbs, foggy thinking, loose stools, and whether damp weather makes it worse.

Maciocio

Weak / Frail

弱 Ruò

FEEL

Forceless, deep, and thin; only felt at the deep level by pressing; lost entirely with more pressure.

INDICATES

Yang Deficiency. Blood Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Soggy**: Weak is deep; Soggy is superficial.

COMBINATIONS

Weak-Choppy — Blood Deficiency

Weak-Fine — severe Blood Deficiency

Weak-Slow — Yang Deficiency

Weak-Soggy — Yang Deficiency with some Dampness

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Deep and yielding. You have to press to find it, and pressing further loses it entirely.

Then what

Yang or Blood is short. Ask about cold, fatigue, and whether they feel worse in the morning or after exertion.

Maciocia

Scattered

散 Sǎn

FEEL

Wide, superficial, forceless, and slack when touched lightly; indistinct; disappears under pressure, rate hard to count.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Flower blossoms lightly scattering to the ground.

INDICATES

Severe Qi and Blood Deficiency. Severe Kidney–Qi Deficiency. A serious condition.

Not to be confused with

vs **Empty**: if you cannot count the rate, it is Scattered. Serious.

COMBINATIONS

Scattered–Slow — severe Qi and Yang Deficiency

Scattered–Rapid — severe Blood Deficiency with Empty–Heat

Scattered–Floating — severe Deficiency of Yuan Qi with floating of Yang, or with Yin Fire

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It has no edges. You can't say where it starts or stops, and you genuinely cannot count it. A dandelion seed-head in wind.

Then what

If you cannot count the rate, stop and take the whole picture seriously. This is a depletion finding that warrants escalation, not a subtle variant.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Hidden

伏 Fú

FEEL

Cannot be felt touching, seeking, or pressing — only felt pressing very heavily to the bone.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Pulsation seeming to come from beneath the bone and tendons.

INDICATES

Severe Yang Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Deep**: Deep is findable with firm pressure; Hidden is not.

COMBINATIONS

Hidden-Full — Qi and Blood stagnation; retention of food; internal Cold; internal Heat

Hidden-Empty — severe Yang Deficiency with internal Cold

Hidden-Rapid — interior Heat

Hidden-Slow — interior Cold

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Absent through light, medium, and deep. Only bone-level pressure finds anything. Beginners routinely mistake this for their own technique failing.

Then what

Before concluding Hidden, check your hand position and pressure. Then take it seriously — severe Yang Deficiency, or extreme pain and collapse states.

Maciocia

Moving

動 Dòng

FEEL

Rapid and slippery; forceful specifically at the middle portion.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A bean bouncing in the vessel — well-defined peaks, no head or tail.

INDICATES

Shock, anxiety, fright. Pain.

Not to be confused with

vs **Slippery**: Moving is forceful only at the middle, like a bean.

COMBINATIONS

Moving-Rapid — Heat

Moving-Slippery — Deficiency of Qi and Phlegm

Moving-Empty — severe depletion of Blood

Moving-Weak — Shock

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A single bean flicking under one fingertip. Short, rounded, forceful — no lead-in and no tail. It startles you slightly.

Then what

Ask about recent shock, fright, or acute pain. This is often a state rather than a constitution.

Bīn Hú Mài Xué

Hasty

促 Cù

FEEL

Beats rapidly with irregular, random stops.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Agitated and urgent, like a man running and suddenly falling down.

INDICATES

Severe Heat. Deficiency of Heart-Qi. Heart-Fire.

Not to be confused with

vs **Knotted**: Hasty is rapid; Knotted is slow.

COMBINATIONS

Hasty-Overflowing — Heat in the Stomach

Hasty-Slippery — retention of Phlegm-Heat

Hasty-Wiry — Liver-Fire and Heart-Fire

Hasty-Slippery-Wiry — Heart-Fire, Liver-Fire, and Phlegm-Heat

Hasty-Fine without strength — collapse of Heart-Qi

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Fast and stumbling. Like someone running who trips, recovers, runs, trips again — irregular, at speed.

Then what

Note the speed AND the pause pattern before you name it. Rapid with random stops = Hasty. Slow with random stops = Knotted.

Maciocia

Knotted

結 Jié

FEEL

Slow with irregularly missed beats; the pulse resumes immediately after the missed beat.

INDICATES

Cold with Heart-Yang Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Hasty**: Knotted is SLOW + random stops; Hasty is RAPID + random stops.

COMBINATIONS

Knotted-Choppy — Blood Stasis

Knotted-Slippery — retention of Phlegm

Knotted-Deep — accumulation in the Interior

Knotted-Wiry — disease of the arteries, or hypertension

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Slow with a hiccup. Beat, beat, gap, beat — and it picks straight back up as though nothing happened.

Then what

Same rule: check speed first. Knotted is the slow one. If it also feels taut, that combination is worth a referral conversation.

Maciocia

Intermittent

代 Dài

FEEL

Pauses at REGULAR intervals; resumes after the pause.

INDICATES

Serious problem in the internal organs. Heart problem (Western medical sense).

Not to be confused with

vs **Knotted/Hasty**: pauses at REGULAR intervals. Most serious of the three.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

The unsettling one, because there's a pattern. Skip on the fourth beat. Then again on the fourth. Regularity inside the irregularity.

Then what

Count several cycles to confirm the pattern is real. If the pauses are genuinely regular, this needs a cardiac referral — not a treatment principle.

Maciocia

Hurried / Racing

疾 Jí

FEEL

Rapid, beating more than seven times per breath (140–180bpm) — an extreme version of Rapid; rhythm stays regular.

INDICATES

Fire exhausting Yin.

Not to be confused with

vs **Hasty**: Racing is over 7/breath but REGULAR.

COMBINATIONS

Hurried-Floating — severe Empty-Heat from Yin Deficiency

Hurried-Floating-Empty — severe Yin Deficiency

Hurried-Slippery — Empty-Heat from Yin Deficiency with Phlegm

Hurried-Overflowing — Empty-Heat arising from Yin Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Extremely fast but perfectly even — no stumbles. A metronome set far too high.

Then what

Confirm it's regular, which separates it from Hasty. Then check for fever, dehydration, thyroid issues, and escalate if it's sustained.

Maciocia

Red flags — refer

Finding	Means
Intermittent 代	Regular pauses — organ / cardiac. Refer.
Scattered 散	Loses shape, rate uncountable. Serious.
Hasty + Fine, no strength	Collapse of Heart-Qi. Escalate.
Hurried/Racing 疾	Over 7/breath. Fire exhausting Yin.
Hollow + Rapid	Forthcoming hemorrhage.
Flooding in winter	Excess Yang against the season.
Knotted + Wiry	Arterial disease or hypertension.

A pulse you cannot count, cannot find, or that stops on a schedule is a referral conversation — not a treatment-principle conversation.

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Part Three — Tongue Diagnosis will append after Week 4. Keep the numbering continuous.

Primary: Prof. Daniel Schrier lecture slides & transcripts, EAM310 Weeks 2–3. Supporting: Maciocia, *Foundations of Chinese Medicine* 3rd ed. · Kaptchuk, *The Web That Has No Weaver* · Li Shizhen, *Bīn Hú Mài Xué* · Deadman, *A Manual of Acupuncture* · Shen Hammer, *Contemporary Pulse Diagnosis*. All outside material paraphrased.